

SOCIETY · HEALTH

Should the government help you make friends?

Japan and the United Kingdom both have a minister for loneliness. Is that a caring idea, or is the state going too far?

NAME

DATE

THE EXERCISES MATCH THE ONLINE PAGE

1 in 6

people in the world feel lonely (WHO, 2025)

871,000

deaths a year linked to loneliness

40%

of people in Japan feel lonely at least from time to time

#9999

Japan's phone line for anyone who needs to talk

In February 2021, Japan gave one of its ministers an unusual job: fighting loneliness¹. Only one country had tried it before. Three years earlier, the British prime minister, Theresa May, asked a junior minister, Tracey Crouch, to lead² the United Kingdom's work on the problem. She said she wanted everyone to take action against the loneliness of older people, carers and people who had lost loved ones³.

A QUIET PROBLEM

Loneliness is more common than most of us think. In 2025, the World Health Organization said that about one in six people in the world feel lonely⁴. It linked⁵ loneliness to around 871,000 deaths a year, roughly 100 every hour. Doctors warn that it raises the risk⁶ of stroke, heart disease and dementia.

In Japan, about 40% of people said in 2024 that they felt lonely at least from time to time⁷. The surprise was the age of the loneliest: not older people, but people in their twenties and thirties.

WHAT JAPAN DID

Since April 2024, a Japanese law has made the national government and local governments take action⁸ against loneliness. It asks cities to set up⁹ local councils, so that hospitals, social workers and volunteers can share information.

The government also trains ordinary citizens, called "connection supporters", to notice people who are isolated¹⁰ and help them find support. Anyone who needs to talk can call #9999. And the state has given more than 6 billion yen to community groups.

"No minister can make you a friend."

The one point both sides agree on

A WALK ON PRESCRIPTION

The UK chose a different tool. There, a family doctor can refer¹¹ a lonely patient to a "link worker", who helps them choose an activity in the neighbourhood¹²: a walking group, a choir, a gardening club. Doctors call it "social prescribing". Nobody makes the patient go, but the link worker encourages them to try.

HELP OR INTERFERENCE?

Supporters say loneliness is a health problem, so the state should treat it like one. Governments make people wear seat belts and encourage¹³ them to stop smoking. Why shouldn't they help them connect¹⁴?

Critics are less sure. Friendship, they say, can't be ordered by the government. Some worry that the state wants people to rely on¹⁵ it for things that

families and neighbours used to do. Others point out that only eight countries have a national plan, and none of them has proved that its plan works.

On one point, both sides agree: no minister can make you a friend. The real question is whether a government can make it easier to find one.

Sources: WHO Commission on Social Connection (2025), via Health Policy Watch; Cabinet Office of Japan, "Japan's Efforts to Tackle Loneliness and Isolation" (2025); Institute for Social Vision Design (2024 survey); NPR (2018); British Red Cross (social prescribing).

CHUNKS FROM THE ARTICLE Os números batem com as palavras sublinhadas no texto

1 fighting loneliness combater a solidão	2 lead liderar	3 lost loved ones perdido pessoas queridas
4 feel lonely se sentem sozinhas	5 linked associou	6 raises the risk aumenta o risco
7 from time to time de vez em quando	8 take action tomar providências	9 set up criar, montar
10 isolated isoladas	11 refer encaminhar	12 neighbourhood bairro
13 encourage incentivam	14 connect criar laços	15 rely on depende de

COMMENTS 7 readers · fictional voices for this lesson

- KS

Keiko S. · São Paulo
My mother lived alone in Osaka until she was 91. A volunteer from the city visited her every Thursday, and she always made tea for him. I want governments to keep paying for this kind of help. It made her week.
- RA

Roberto A. · Campinas
Nobody is going to make me join a choir. I like my own company. The state should let people stay at home if they want to, and spend the money on hospitals.
- LM

Lúcia M. · replying to Roberto
Being alone and being lonely aren't the same thing, Roberto. Nobody wants to make you sing. But when my husband died, I didn't leave the house for months. I needed someone to knock on my door.
- TH

Tom H. · Manchester
After my wife died, my doctor suggested that I join a walking group. I didn't want to go. My daughter made me try it once. That was three years ago. Now I walk every Tuesday, and we have coffee afterwards.
- FR

Fernanda R. · replying to Tom
Lovely story, Tom, but it was your daughter who helped you, not the government. Families should do this job, not ministers. Don't let the state take care of everything.
- HT

Hiro T. · Curitiba · teacher
The loneliest people are young, and they spend all day on their phones. I'd like schools to teach children to talk to each other. I tell my students to put their phones away at lunch.
- MV

Marta V. · Belo Horizonte
I'd recommend that every city have a phone line like Japan's #9999. When you're lonely at 2 a.m., you can't call the minister.

Same numbers as the online page. Os números batem com a página da aula.

1 True or false?

Verdadeiro ou falso?

Read the sentence. Is it true, according to the article? Circle T or F.

Se for falso, corrija na linha com o que o texto diz.

Example The WHO linked loneliness to about 871 deaths a year.

T **F**

Procure WHO no texto. O número está errado.

Around 871,000 deaths a year.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 Japan gave a minister the job of fighting loneliness in 2021.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

2 Japan was the first country with a minister for loneliness.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

3 Theresa May asked Tracey Crouch to lead the UK's work on loneliness.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

4 According to the WHO, about one in six people in the world feel lonely.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

5 In Japan, older people are the loneliest group.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

6 The Japanese law makes the government take action against loneliness.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

7 Japan pays connection supporters to visit every older person.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

8 In the UK, doctors make lonely patients join a choir.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

9 Some critics worry that people will rely on the state instead of their families.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

10 Many countries have proved that their loneliness plans work.

T F

IF IT'S FALSE · se for falso, corrija

2 Who said it?

Quem disse isso nos comentários?

Read the comments again. Circle the reader.

Todas as respostas estão nos comentários, embaixo da matéria.

Example

Who asked Tracey Crouch to lead the UK's work?

Essa pessoa está no texto, não nos comentários.

A Theresa May B Tom C Keiko

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 Who wants governments to keep paying for volunteers?

A Keiko B Tom C Hiro

2 Who thinks the state should let people stay at home?

A Fernanda B Roberto C Marta

3 Who needed someone to knock on her door?

A Keiko B Fernanda C Lúcia

4 Whose doctor suggested that he join a walking group?

A Tom B Roberto C Hiro

5 Who thinks families should do this job, not ministers?

A Hiro B Fernanda C Keiko

6 Who would like schools to teach children to talk to each other?

A Lúcia B Marta C Hiro

7 Who would recommend that every city have a phone line?

A Marta B Tom C Roberto

3 Listen and answer

Ouçe e responda

Open the online page, exercise 3, and play each story. Circle the answer.

O áudio está na página da aula. Os números batem com os da tela.

Example ▶ What does the neighbour invite her to do?

O vizinho faz um convite: invite + pessoa + to.

- A **have lunch with them** B knock on the door

The neighbour invites her to have lunch with them.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 ▶ What does her son want her to do?

- A take a computer class B call him on Tuesdays C move to a new flat

2 ▶ What did the doctor tell him to do?

- A stay at home and rest B go to a walking group C see her again on Thursday

3 ▶ What does the centre let people do?

- A pay at the door B become members C use the computers for free

4 ▶ What did her granddaughter ask her to do?

- A send a message every morning B buy a new phone C visit her at the weekend

5 ▶ What does the organiser tell the volunteers not to do?

- A visit people alone B talk about money C come to the meetings

6 ▶ What did his wife make him do?

- A learn to drive B sing at home C go to the choir

7 ▶ What does the nurse suggest?

- A that the city open the gardens on Saturdays B that children visit the clinic C that older people work at the school

8 ▶ What doesn't his daughter want?

- A him to call her every day B him to feel old C him to make new friends

4 Pick the pattern

Escolha a estrutura

Circle the words that complete the sentence.

let / make / have + pessoa + verbo; want / ask / tell / encourage + pessoa + to; suggest / recommend + that.

Example The UK asked doctors _____ lonely patients to link workers.

Ask é Família 1: ask + pessoa + to.

A refer B **to refer** C referring

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 Her grandson makes her _____ a coat when it's cold.

A wear B to wear C wearing

2 The volunteers want older people _____ them for help.

A ask B asking C to ask

3 The nurse suggested _____ more water.

A him to drink B that he drink C he drink

4 My neighbour lets me _____ her garden.

A use B to use C using

5 The club encourages new members _____ a friend.

A bring B to bring C bringing

6 My son wants me _____ a smartphone class.

A take B to take C taking

7 The doctor had me _____ my blood pressure every day.

A check B to check C checking

8 The teacher won't let the students _____ their phones.

A using B to use C use

9 Grandma told us _____ late for dinner.

A don't be B not be C not to be

10 I'd recommend _____ a choir.

A you to join B you joining C that you join

5 Fill the gap

Complete a frase

Use the verb in brackets. Write one, two or three words.

Às vezes é só o verbo, às vezes **to** + verbo, às vezes **not to** + verbo.

Example Tom's daughter didn't let him miss the first walk. (miss)

Let é Família 2: let + pessoa + verbo, sem to.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 The city lets volunteers _____ older people at home. (visit)

2 My granddaughter wants me _____ her more often. (call)

3 The club made everyone _____ their name on a card. (write)

4 The doctor advised her _____ at home all day. (not / stay)

5 Japan wants its citizens _____ their neighbours. (notice)

6 I'd like my grandchildren _____ Japanese. (learn)

7 Her friend suggested that she _____ a cooking class. (join)

8 Please don't let me _____ my medicine. (forget)

6 Ask and answer

Pergunte e responda

Use the words. Write the question and the answer.

A estrutura não muda na pergunta: **let / make** + pessoa + verbo; **train / encourage / would like** + pessoa + **to**.

Example What / Japan / let / anyone / do / on #9999

Let é Família 2. Na pergunta entra does, e let fica na base.

QUESTION · pergunta

What does Japan let anyone do on #9999?

ANSWER · resposta

It lets them talk to someone.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 What / the law / make / the government / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

2 What / Japan / train / ordinary citizens / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

3 Who / Theresa May / ask / to lead the UK's work

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

4 What / the link worker / encourage / patients / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

5 What / Tom's doctor / suggest

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

6 What / Hiro / would like / schools / do

QUESTION · pergunta

ANSWER · resposta

7 What did they say?

Conte o que os leitores disseram

Report it. Use the verb in brackets.

O pedido vira **verb + pessoa + to**; o "não faça" vira **not to**; suggest e recommend pedem **that**.

Example

Keiko to her mother: "Make tea for the volunteer." (ask)

Ask é Família 1: ask + pessoa + to.

Keiko asked her mother to make tea for the volunteer.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 Keiko to the city: "Please keep paying for the volunteers." (ask)

2 Roberto to the government: "Don't make me join a choir." (tell)

3 **Lúcia to Roberto: "Don't stay at home all the time." (advise)**

4 **Tom's daughter to Tom: "Try the walking group once." (want)**

5 **Tom's doctor: "I recommend that you join a walking group." (recommend)**

6 **Fernanda to the readers: "Don't let the state take care of everything." (warn)**

7 **Hiro to his students: "Put your phones away at lunch." (tell)**

8 **Marta: "Every city should have a phone line." (suggest)**

8 What do you think?

A sua opinião

Finish the sentence with your own ideas.

| Não existe resposta certa. Use a estrutura do começo.

Example Start with: If I met a lonely neighbour, I'd...

Diga o que você faria, com invite, ask ou let + pessoa.

If I met a lonely neighbour, I'd invite her to have tea with me.

YOUR TURN · agora é você

1 **Start with: I'd like the government to...**

2 **Start with: Nobody can make me...**

3 **Start with: I'd recommend that a lonely neighbour...**

4 Start with: When I was young, my parents didn't let me...

9 Take a side

Para a conversa em sala

Choose a side. Note two arguments of your own.

Escolha um lado e anote dois argumentos seus antes da conversa.

FOR · A FAVOR

The government should help people connect

- Loneliness is a health problem, and it costs lives.
- Some people have no family nearby.
- Small things, like a phone line or a visit, can change someone's week.

Useful: **I'd like the state to...** · **It helps people...** · **Look at Japan:**

AGAINST · CONTRA

Friendship is a private matter

- The state can't make people like each other.
- Families and neighbours should do this job.
- The money could go to hospitals.

Useful: **Nobody can make me...** · **I don't want the government to...** · **Families should...**

MY ARGUMENTS · meus argumentos

TALK ABOUT YOU conversa

1. Who do you talk to every day? Who makes you laugh?
2. When you were young, did your parents let you go out alone? What did they make you do at home?
3. What would you like your city to do for people who live alone?
4. Would you join a walking group or a choir if your doctor suggested it? Why, or why not?

Telling people what to do

Three families. The person always comes right after the verb.

1 verb + person + to

want · would like · ask · tell · advise · warn · force · expect

O "não" entra antes do to: **not to**.

The coach **told** us **to** arrive early.

My doctor **advised** me **not to** skip breakfast.

2 let / make / have + person + verb

Sem to. O verbo fica na base.

Na pergunta, só o auxiliar muda.

Our manager **let** us leave at four.

Does the school **make** students wear a uniform?

3 suggest / recommend + that + person + verb

O verbo fica na base, sem -s, mesmo com he / she.

Não existe suggest him to.

The lawyer **suggested that** she **sign** the contract today.

I **recommend that** he **take** the train.

Self-check

Marque o que você já consegue fazer

☐ I can follow a news article about society and find the facts.

Consigo acompanhar uma matéria sobre sociedade e achar os fatos.

☐ I can understand a short story and say what someone wants, asks or lets people do.

Consigo ouvir uma história curta e dizer o que alguém quer, pede ou deixa fazer.

☐ I can report what people told, asked or warned others to do.

Consigo contar o que alguém pediu, disse ou avisou para outra pessoa fazer.

☐ I can give my opinion with I'd like... to and I suggest that...

Consigo dar minha opinião com I'd like... to e I suggest that...